



Dispatching the Driver & the BOL

Ace Dispatch · Dispatcher Training Course

Module 12 of 18 · Running the Load · about a 14-minute read

You did all of it — booked, priced, scheduled, signed the rate con. Now Marcus heads to Atlanta to pick up. But all you gave him was the address. At the gate they ask for the pickup number; he doesn't have it, so he calls you and sits for forty minutes while you dig it up. He finally gets loaded — but he's tired, and he just signs the paperwork the shipper hands him without counting. Turns out two pieces of furniture never made it onto the truck. Summit just signed for thirty-eight thousand pounds it didn't fully receive, and now the carrier could eat that claim. Oh — and Marcus is low on fuel, with no money to make it to Dallas.

Every one of those is a dispatching miss, and every one was preventable. Because dispatching isn't "go pick it up."

Dispatching is handing the driver a complete, correct package, making sure the pickup is executed and documented right, and setting him up with the cash to run. Get it wrong and the cleanest deal you ever put together quietly comes apart at the dock. Get it right and the load runs like it's supposed to.

WHAT YOU'LL BE ABLE TO DO

Send a driver off on a load with everything he needs: the full pickup and delivery details so he's never stuck at a gate, the know-how to check and sign the bill of lading correctly so the carrier is protected, and a fuel advance set up so he's got the cash to run. You'll turn your paperwork into a driver who's rolling, prepared, and covered.

1 Dispatching Is the Handoff

Everything you've built so far — the booked load, the negotiated rate, the appointments, the signed rate con — now has to be handed to the one person who actually executes it: the driver. That handoff is **dispatching**. It means giving the driver a complete, correct package so he can get to the pickup, load, haul, and deliver without guessing or getting stuck.

Here's why it deserves real care: the driver only knows what you tell him. Leave out the pickup number and he's stranded at a gate. Forget to mention it's an early FCFS pickup and he shows up at noon to a five-hour line. Your prep is his marching orders — so dispatching well is mostly about being *complete*. Let's go through exactly what "complete" means.

2 The Dispatch: What the Driver Needs

Give the driver everything for the pickup and the run — and put it in writing, a **dispatch sheet** or a clear message, so he's not running on memory. The full package looks like this:

DISPATCH SHEET		To: Marcus · Unit 7 dry van
the rate con's information, turned into the driver's instructions		
THE PICKUP		
SHIPPER	Atlanta shipper · full address	
WHEN	Tuesday · FCFS — be there ~7:00 AM (beat the line)	
PICKUP / PO #	give at the gate · check in at the shipping office	
THE DELIVERY		
RECEIVER	Dallas receiver · address	
APPOINTMENT	Thursday 1:00 PM (the time you set)	
THE LOAD & NUMBERS		
FREIGHT	Furniture · ~38,000 lbs · 20 pieces · dry van	
REFERENCE	Smith Logistics load # · rate con on file	
CONTACTS		
REACH	Broker (Smith) # · your #	
THE RULE	Call me the second anything's off.	
The test: could the driver execute this whole pickup without calling you for a missing detail? If yes, you've dispatched him well.		

3 The BOL: Check It, Note Problems, Then Sign

At the pickup, the driver deals with the single most important piece of paper on the freight side: the **bill of lading**, the **BOL**. It's the official record of the shipment — it lists the shipper and receiver and exactly what's being shipped: the commodity, the piece count, and the weight. It's both the receipt for the goods and, legally, the contract to carry them. Keep it straight from the rate con: the rate con is the *deal* with the broker; the BOL is the *receipt for the physical freight*, signed at the dock when it's loaded.

And here's the part you must drill into every driver, because it protects the carrier from claims that aren't its fault. **Before he signs the BOL, the driver counts and inspects the freight against it, notes any problem right on the document, and only then signs.**

BILL OF LADING — check before signing

signed at the dock, when the freight is loaded

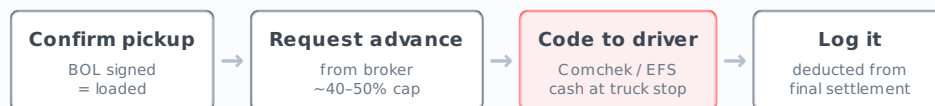
SHIPPER → RECEIVER	Atlanta shipper → Dallas receiver
COMMODITY	Furniture
PIECE COUNT	20 pieces COUNT IT
CONDITION	Inspect for visible damage INSPECT IT
EXCEPTIONS	Anything short / damaged / wrong — write it here <i>before</i> signing NOTE IT
SEAL #	If sealed: write the seal number, don't break it in transit
A clean BOL means the carrier accepted that freight in good, complete order. Sign clean when two pieces were actually missing, and the carrier can be blamed for a loss that happened before it ever touched the freight. Sign for <i>exactly</i> what you received.	

So the rule is simple and absolute: **count it, inspect it, note the exceptions, then sign** — and keep a copy. A problem written on the BOL before signing is called an *exception* or notation ("*two pieces damaged*," "*one pallet short*"). And if the load is sealed, the numbered **seal** on the trailer doors is the proof the freight wasn't opened in transit — the driver records that number and the receiver confirms it's intact at delivery. A BOL signed this way is the carrier's shield.

4 Getting the Driver Cash: Fuel Advances and Comchek

Now a money problem you'll solve constantly. The carrier usually won't get paid for this load for thirty days — but the driver needs money to *run* it *now*: fuel, maybe a lumper at the dock. The fix is a **fuel advance** — a portion of the load's pay released up front, before the load delivers and the invoice is paid. You typically request it from the broker once pickup is confirmed by the BOL, and brokers will usually advance up to something like forty to fifty percent of the linehaul, for a small fee.

The usual mechanism is a **Comchek** — an express-code check or payment code (you'll also hear Comdata or EFS) that the broker or your factor issues. The driver cashes the code at a truck stop, or it pays a lumper directly. So the operational flow is:



That last step matters: the advance is **deducted from the load's final settlement**, so it has to be noted. This is the real-world version of the fuel advance from the money lesson — a code that turns next-month's money into fuel in the tank today.

5 Send Him Off Right, and Stay Reachable

Before you call the dispatch done, close the loop. Confirm the driver actually has everything — the full pickup and delivery details, the appointment times, and his fuel or cash sorted — and that he knows the one rule that matters most while he's rolling: call you the instant anything goes sideways, a delay, a problem at the dock, a breakdown. The handoff isn't finished when the truck leaves the yard; it's finished when the driver is moving with everything he needs *and* a clear line back to you.

Because the moment those wheels start turning, your job shifts — from setting the load up to watching it move. And that's exactly where we go next.

Walkthrough — Dispatching Marcus on the Anchor Load

Rate con signed, packet on file — time to send him. Watch the three pieces come together: the dispatch, the BOL at pickup, and the fuel advance.

THE DISPATCH — TO MARCUS, IN WRITING

PICKUP	Atlanta shipper — Tue, FCFS, be there ~7:00 AM; pickup #, check in at the shipping office.
DELIVERY	Dallas receiver — Thursday 1:00 PM appointment.
LOAD	Furniture, ~38,000 lbs, 20 pieces , dry van.
NUMBERS	Smith Logistics load #, rate con on file.
CONTACTS	Smith's #, your #, "call me the second anything's off."

AT PICKUP — THE BOL

BOL LISTS	20 pieces, ~38,000 lbs, furniture, shipper → Dallas receiver.
MARCUS	Counts: 20 pieces ✓ Inspects: no visible damage ✓ → signs, keeps a copy.
If 2 had been damaged: he writes "2 pieces damaged" on the BOL <i>before</i> signing — never sign clean for freight you didn't fully receive.	

FUEL ADVANCE

NEED	Marcus needs fuel money (~\$400). Pickup confirmed by BOL.
REQUEST	You ask Smith for an advance (cap ~40% of the \$3,000 linehaul → up to ~\$1,200).
ISSUE	Smith issues a Comchek code (minus a small fee); Marcus cashes it at a truck stop.

You note the \$400 advance — it's deducted from the load's final settlement. → Marcus is rolling: loaded, BOL signed clean, fuel in the tank, knows Thursday 1:00 PM.

See what made that dispatch work: Marcus never had to call for a missing detail, he signed the BOL for *exactly* what he counted — protecting Summit — and he had cash to run before the load ever pays out. Nothing left to chance, nothing left at the dock. Now the truck's moving, and you watch it.

Module 12 Glossary — your quick reference

The handoff toolkit — what gets the driver rolling and protected.

The handoff

- Dispatching** Handing the driver a complete, correct package — pickup, delivery, load, numbers, contacts — so he can run the load without guessing.
- Dispatch sheet** The written package itself: the rate con's information turned into the driver's marching orders.

At the dock

- Bill of lading (BOL)** The official record and receipt of the freight, signed at pickup — also the contract of carriage. The driver counts, inspects, notes exceptions, then signs for exactly what he received.
- Seal** A numbered tag on the trailer doors of a sealed load; recorded on the BOL and confirmed intact at delivery — proof the freight wasn't opened in transit.

Cash to run

- Fuel advance** A portion of the load's pay released up front so the driver can buy fuel or pay a lumper before net-30 pay arrives — deducted from the final settlement. (Introduced in the money lesson.)
- Comchek (Comdata / EFS)** The express payment code that delivers a fuel advance — cashed at a truck stop or used to pay a lumper directly.

Check yourself

Try these from memory first, then check your answers below.

1. **What does it mean to dispatch a driver, and name three things he needs from you.**
2. **What is the bill of lading, and what must the driver do before signing it?**
3. **At pickup the driver sees two pieces are damaged. What should he do?**
4. **What is a fuel advance, and how does the driver usually get it?**
5. **Once you've dispatched the driver, what do you confirm before he rolls?**

ANSWERS

1. Hand the driver a complete package to execute the load. Any three of: pickup (address, date, appointment-or-FCFS, PO number, check-in); delivery (address + appointment time); load details (commodity, weight, pieces, equipment); reference numbers; and contacts (broker, you, and "call if anything's off").
2. The official record and receipt of the freight, signed at pickup (also the contract of carriage). Before signing, the driver counts and inspects the freight against the BOL and notes any shortage or damage as an exception — he signs for exactly what he received.
3. Write the damage on the BOL (an exception/notation) *before* signing — don't sign a clean BOL, or the carrier can be blamed for damage that wasn't its fault.
4. A portion of the load's pay released up front (so the driver can buy fuel or pay a lump sum before net-30 pay arrives). Usually requested from the broker after pickup is confirmed, commonly via a Comchek/express code cashed at a truck stop; it's deducted from the final settlement.
5. That he has everything (pickup/delivery details, appointment times), his fuel/cash is sorted, and he knows to call you the moment anything goes wrong.

WHAT'S NEXT → MODULE 13: CHECK CALLS & TRACKING

Your driver is rolling now — loaded, the BOL signed for exactly what's on the truck, fuel in the tank, the delivery time locked in his head. But your job isn't to wave goodbye at the gate. A load in motion still needs watching: from pickup to delivery you stay on top of where that truck is and keep the broker in the loop, so a small delay never turns into a nasty surprise for anyone. Next, we cover how you keep tabs on a moving load — check calls and tracking.

YOUR COMPANY'S PLAYBOOK

This lesson teaches dispatching, BOL handling, and the fuel advance as generic skills. Your own operation adds its specifics — its dispatch sheet template and the exact info every driver gets; its BOL policy for what drivers must verify and how exceptions are recorded and reported back; its fuel-advance process (who requests it, the cap and fee it works with, how Comchek/EFS codes are issued and relayed, and how advances are logged against settlement); how advances and a factor interact if it factors; and how a dispatched load is handed to tracking and who to escalate to when a pickup goes wrong. *Your trainer or supervisor will fill these in.*

